

Before the Meeting: A Difficult Conversation

Ten minutes of preparation before you sit down with a family.

COMMUNICATION

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

If anyone could get hurt, get another adult.

Restraint and seclusion are not de-escalation tools. Imminent danger only, trained staff only. [NASP 2021]

THE DAY BEFORE

- ☐ **Write the one sentence you need them to leave with.**
If you cannot get it to one sentence, the meeting is not ready.
- ☐ **Check what has already been sent home.**
Arriving with news they received in an email three weeks ago costs you the room.
- ☐ **Book a room with a door that closes.**

IN THE FIRST TWO MINUTES

- ☐ **Say what you appreciate about the child, specifically.**
Specific means an incident and a date, not a compliment.

SAY

On Tuesday she stayed behind to help pack up. Nobody asked her to.

- ☐ **Name the purpose of the meeting out loud.**
Families arrive braced. Saying it removes the guessing.

What is deliberately not here

Any technique for you to walk the student through. That is treatment, and it is not your job here.

Sources: NCTSN Child Trauma Toolkit for Educators pp.4-6; NASP 2021.

NOTES